

בְּרֵאשִׁית

Bereshit

Genesis 1:1–6:8 — Creation, Eden, Cain and Abel, ten generations to Noah

Mega Bible
parasha sheet
theothermatthewmiller.com

THE PARASHA BY THE NUMBERS

146

VERSES

1931

WORDS

368

DISTINCT ROOTS

5

HAPAX LEGOMENA

MOST FREQUENT ROOTS

אֱלֹהִים

God

67

הָיָה

to be, become

62

כָּל

all, every

53

שָׁנָה

year

50

אָמַר

he said

42

יָלַד

he begot, bore

42

יוֹם

day

37

אָדָם

man, Adam

36

ה'

the Name (Hashem)

36

אֶרֶץ

land, earth

35

Averaging **13.2 words** a verse. The longest verse is **2:19** at 28 words — Adam naming every animal one by one; the shortest, **2:1**, has only 5 — the whole of heaven and earth, finished.

WHAT THE PARASHA CALLS GOD

אֱלֹהִים

God

67

ה'

the Name (Hashem)

36

Just two names carry the whole parasha: אֱלֹהִים (Elohim) for the work of creation itself, and ה' once the story turns to the Garden, the first commandment, and Cain — the same two-name pattern the classical commentators read as *din* (judgment) giving way to *rachamim* (mercy).

FIVE WORDS THAT OCCUR NOWHERE ELSE IN THE BIBLE

2:11	פִּישׁוֹן	H6376
Pishon (river name)		
3:19	בְּיָעָת <יָעָה>	H2188
in the sweat of		
4:16	נוֹד	H5113
Nod (land name, "wandering")		
4:20	יָבָל	H2989
Jabal (name)		
4:21	יֹבָל	H3106
Jubal (name)		

Hapax legomena, counted against the whole Tanakh: five of this parasha's 368 roots are used exactly once in all of Scripture, and 149 more appear only once here. Three of the five are proper names (Pishon, Nod, Jabal, Jubal) — Bereshit's ordinary vocabulary is ordinary precisely because it is laying the foundation everything else is built from; its rarest words turn up naming rivers, exiles, and a handful of Cain's own descendants.

1:2 תהו ובהו

the uncreated world's "formless void" becomes the everyday word for utter chaos and mess

תהו ובהו — before the first act of creation, the earth is תהו ובהו, a rhyming pair found nowhere else with this exact sense: shapeless, unformed, not-yet-anything. It describes a state prior to order, not a mess made by disorder. Modern Hebrew flattens the distinction: תהו ובהו now just means chaos or a mess — a messy desk, a chaotic office, a disorganized plan are all תהו ובהו. Israeli publishers have used the phrase as the title of children's books, political pamphlets ("תהו ובהו מדיני", on the political chaos of pre-state settlement) and literary essay collections, always trading on the same everyday sense of disorder rather than the specific pre-creation void of the verse.



Dalia Dance Festival Archive (Kibbutz Dalia), National Library of Israel
FL122898082

1:3 יהי אור

the first divine speech-act becomes a ceremonial phrase for new beginnings and dedications

יהי אור — the first words God speaks, and the first recorded instance of speech bringing something into being. יהי אור ("let there be light") became a stock phrase for inauguration and renewal in modern Hebrew: building dedications, new institutions, and communal ceremonies invoke it as a way of marking a beginning. The National Library's archive of the Dalia Dance Festival — the mass folk-dance gatherings of the Kibbutz movement in the 1940s–50s — preserves a musical number literally titled "יהי אור!", its lyrics and score handwritten in white ink on black paper, using the verse as the festival's own opening flourish.

ATTESTED · NATIONAL LIBRARY OF ISRAEL

יהי אור!

Words and music for "Let there be light!", from the Dalia Dance Festival archive — a folk-dance movement's own creation-themed opening number.

4:9 השׁמֵר אֶחִי אֲנֹכִי

Cain's evasive question becomes the name of a real Israeli advocacy movement

וַיֹּאמֶר לֹא יָדַעְתִּי הַשָּׁמֶר אֶחִי אֲנֹכִי — Cain's defensive deflection, asked instead of answering for his brother, is one of the Torah's most quoted rhetorical questions: an evasion so famous it now reads as an assertion of responsibility rather than a denial of it. "I am my brother's keeper" ("שומר אחי אנוכי") was the actual name of an international campaign organization active from the late 1970s through the 1980s advocating for Soviet Refuseniks, including Natan Sharansky — the National Library's archives hold its posters, notebooks, and campaign files under that name. A 1971 caricature by the Israeli cartoonist Dosh, drawn for Maariv, put the original question mark back: "שומר אחי?!", turning Cain's excuse into a live challenge about international indifference — it survives in the Dosh Archive, though under a restricted-access license that keeps it off this page.

THE SEVEN DAYS, BY WORD COUNT

אֹר	רָקִיעַ	יִבְשָׁה וְצֶמַח	מֵאֲרוֹת	הַגָּה וְעוֹף	חַיָּה וָאָדָם	שָׁבַת
Day 1 — light	Day 2 — sky	Day 3 — land & plants	Day 4 — sun, moon, stars	Day 5 — sea & sky creatures	Day 6 — land animals & humans	Day 7 — rest
52 words	38 words	69 words	69 words	57 words	149 words	35 words

Day Six runs longer than any other two days combined. It is the only day with two separate creative acts — land animals, then humanity — and the only day the text pauses to explain itself: God's own likeness, dominion over the earth, and what everything alive is given to eat. The seventh day is the shortest workday of the week precisely because nothing is made on it at all.

MY NOTES

כִּי טוֹב, repeated six times through the six days (1:4, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25), is usually read "and God saw that it was good." Kugel argues that's a mistranslation: כִּי, often an intensifier ("very," "how!" — compare Gen 18:20's רַבָּהּ (כִּי רַבָּהּ), fused early with טוֹב into an adverb, *kî ṭôb*, "greatly, very much" — the same idiom behind כִּי טוֹב לַה' הוֹדוּ, "praise the LORD greatly." On his reading, Genesis 1's refrain has nothing to do with seeing: וַיֵּרָא אֱלֹהִים כִּי טוֹב "means simply, 'And God was most pleased.'" The contrast cases support him — 6:2's כִּי טַבַּחַת (that they were beautiful") takes the pronoun and gender agreement a true adjectival clause needs, which the bare, unagreeing כִּי טוֹב of Genesis 1 lacks. 3:6, where טוֹב has an explicit referent (לְמַאֲכַל ... לְהַעֲיֹץ), is the one case even Kugel leaves genuinely ambiguous. W. F. Albright had proposed a related "very good" reading in 1957; J. Gerald Janzen pushed back on Kugel's adverbial analysis in a 1983 JBL response.

James L. Kugel, "The Adverbial Use of Kî Ṭôb," Journal of Biblical Literature 99/3 (1980), 433–35

2:8 גֵּן־בְּעֵדֶן מִקְדָּם

In the Torah, the Garden of Eden is located on earth — planted by God "in Eden, in the east," with four rivers (Pishon, Gichon, Chidekel/Tigris, Perat/Euphrates) that flow out into known geography. The Qur'an's Eden (al-Jannah) is generally read as a heavenly paradise rather than an earthly place — worth tracing how that earthly-vs-heavenly framing shapes each tradition's theology of exile, return, and paradise lost and regained.

2:24 בִּשְׁרֵאֶחָד

Connects to Hullin 75's discussion of how far a woman and her newborn count as one entity (basar echad) halachically. Ramban's comment here frames basar echad as the union of man and wife producing a child who is literally the flesh of both — worth tracing whether Ramban's "one flesh" bond is the conceptual root the Hullin sugya draws on for mother-child status.